Haligric Research Integration Series

Blood Type Personality

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Ketsueki-gata — Japan and Korea's Modern, Honestly-Dated, and Genuinely Consequential Personal-Info System

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Four letters — A, B, O, AB — carrying as much cultural weight in Japan and Korea today as a sun sign carries in the West.

Unlike every other system in this sub-queue, this one does not borrow an ancient name. Its origin is dated, documented, and modern by its own admission — a 1927 psychology essay, revived and popularized in the 1970s — and its consequences are neither symbolic nor historical. They are current: dating profiles, hiring bias, and a specific, named form of workplace harassment (bura-hara) that has drawn government and media attention in the twenty-first century.

This is the story of the one system in this collection that never pretended to be old — and precisely because of that honesty, ended up mattering more, in more concrete ways, than almost any of the others.

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Introduction — The One System That Never Claimed to Be Ancient

Ketsueki-gata (血液型, literally "blood type") is the belief, widespread in Japan and, in a related but distinct form, in South Korea, that a person's ABO blood type — A, B, O, or AB — meaningfully predicts their personality, temperament, work style, and romantic compatibility. It functions in everyday cultural life much the way a sun sign functions in the West: a routine getting-to-know-you question, a staple of magazine personality quizzes and matchmaking profiles, a joke and a genuine belief simultaneously depending on who is asked.

This document is the outlier in its five-part sub-queue for one specific reason: every other system covered alongside it (Celtic tree astrology, numerology, the pop Native American zodiac, the modern Egyptian zodiac) presents itself, explicitly or through omission, as older than it actually is, reaching backward for an ancient name or civilization to lend itself unearned authority. Ketsueki-gata does not do this. Its modern, twentieth-century, Japanese origin is not hidden or contested — it is openly known and dated even by the people who believe in it. What makes it worth documenting with the same seriousness as the others is not a hidden-history reveal but the opposite: a system with no false-antiquity problem at all still managed to produce real, measurable, twenty-first-century social harm, which is a different and in some ways more important lesson than the one the other four documents teach.

Origins — Takeji Furukawa's 1927 Essay

The system's documented origin point is a 1927 essay, "The Study of Temperament Through Blood Type," by Takeji Furukawa, a professor at Tokyo Women's Teacher's School who was not a geneticist or a physician but a scholar of education and psychology. Furukawa's essay proposed, based on a small and methodologically weak survey of his own students and acquaintances, that the four ABO blood types corresponded to four distinct temperament clusters — an idea that fit comfortably within a broader international interwar fascination with scientific-sounding typologies of human character (the same era that produced phrenology's later respectable cousins and various constitutional-psychology systems in Europe and America).

Furukawa's work received serious academic attention and criticism at the time, including formal rebuttals from Japanese psychologists who pointed out the statistical weakness of his sample and methodology — a scholarly pushback that, notably, happened within a few years of the theory's publication, unlike the slower or absent academic reckonings some of the other systems in this sub-queue took decades to receive.

The Wartime Interlude and Postwar Dormancy

Blood-type typology saw a darker application in the years leading up to and during the Second World War, when some Japanese military and research institutions reportedly explored blood-type-based personnel assignment and even, per some historical accounts, less benign applications tied to the era's broader (and now thoroughly discredited) scientific-racial thinking. After the war, the theory fell into general dormancy and skepticism for roughly three decades, receiving little serious popular or academic attention through the 1950s and 1960s.

Masahiko Nomi and the 1970s Revival

The system's modern popular form owes almost entirely to Masahiko Nomi, a broadcaster and writer with no formal background in genetics or psychology, who revived and substantially expanded blood-type personality theory starting in 1971 with his book Understanding Affinity

by Blood Type. Nomi was a prolific popularizer rather than a researcher — he produced dozens of blood-type-themed books over the following decade, covering blood-type compatibility in romance, blood-type-appropriate career paths, and blood-type parenting advice, and it is substantially Nomi's specific framework, elaborated further after his death by his son Toshitaka Nomi, that underlies the personality profiles in circulation today.

Nomi's revival coincided with, and was amplified by, a broader 1970s-80s boom in Japanese mass-media personality content — magazine quizzes, television variety segments, and eventually manga and anime characterization shorthand (Japanese fiction routinely assigns and references characters' blood types as an immediately legible personality cue, a convention with no equivalent in most other national storytelling traditions) — that embedded the belief far more deeply into ordinary popular culture than Furukawa's original academic essay ever achieved on its own.

The Four Types — Complete Breakdown

Type	Approx. Prevalence (Japan)	Assigned Traits & Note
Type A	≈40% of Japanese population	Earnest, careful, cooperative, perfectionistic, anxious under pressure — the type most consistently associated with conscientiousness and social harmony (wa) across the tradition's sources; also the type most often described as prone to overthinking and stress.
Type B	≈20% of Japanese population	Individualistic, creative, spontaneous, passionate about personal interests — also the type most consistently subject to negative stereotyping in the tradition, frequently characterized as selfish or unreliable, a bias documented in the bura-hara discussion below.
Type O	≈30% of Japanese population	Confident, ambitious, sociable, natural leaders, goal-oriented — generally the most positively stereotyped type across the tradition's popular sources, often associated with romantic and professional success.
Type AB	≈10% of Japanese population	Complex, rational, dual-natured, described as combining Type A's caution with Type B's spontaneity — often characterized as the hardest type to categorize or predict, sometimes stereotyped as two-faced or unpredictable as a direct consequence of that dual-natured framing.

Population prevalence figures are approximate and vary somewhat by source and region; they are included because, unusually among the systems in this sub-queue, ketsueki-gata's four categories are not evenly or arbitrarily distributed — real ABO blood-type frequency genuinely does vary by population, which lends the system a surface plausibility (real, measurable biological variation exists) that the arbitrary date-range or letter-assignment systems in the other four documents lack, even though prevalence variation has no established causal link to personality.

How Deep the Belief Runs — Dating, Hiring, Daycare

Ketsueki-gata's social penetration in Japan is substantially deeper than a typical Western sun-sign reference. Dating and matchmaking services, including major commercial ones, have offered blood-type-based compatibility matching as a standard feature. It is common and unremarkable for Japanese people to know their own and close acquaintances' blood types the way Westerners might know a friend's star sign, and blood type is a standard, expected item of small talk and self-introduction in many social contexts. More consequentially, there have been documented instances of companies asking about blood type on job application materials or informally factoring it into hiring and team-assignment decisions, and some schools and

daycare facilities have organized children into activity groups by blood type on the theory that certain type combinations work or play better together.

Bura-hara — Blood Type Harassment as a Named Social Problem

The Japanese term bura-hara (a portmanteau of "blood" and "harassment," modeled on the pattern of pawa-hara for power harassment and seku-hara for sexual harassment) names a specific, recognized category of workplace and social discrimination based on blood type — most commonly directed at Type B and, in some contexts, Type AB individuals, who are the types most negatively stereotyped in the popular tradition. Documented instances include exclusion from promotions or specific work assignments, negative performance assumptions made explicitly on the basis of blood type, and social exclusion or teasing in school and workplace settings. The topic has received sustained coverage in Japanese media and has prompted public commentary from psychologists and social researchers specifically warning against blood-type-based discrimination in hiring and interpersonal judgment.

This is the single clearest instance across this entire five-part sub-queue of a personal-info system producing directly attributable, contemporary, real-world discriminatory harm with a specific documented name — distinct from the historical or appropriation-related harms discussed in the Native American zodiac and Egyptian zodiac documents, which concern cultural ownership and misrepresentation rather than direct interpersonal discrimination against individuals based on the trait itself.

The Scientific Verdict — What Actual Research Finds

Peer-reviewed psychological research has consistently failed to find a reliable, replicable correlation between ABO blood type and personality traits when tested under standard psychometric conditions. Multiple studies conducted by Japanese researchers themselves — including work specifically designed to test Nomi's claims empirically, given the theory's outsized cultural presence in Japan — have found no statistically significant relationship between blood type and standard personality measures once proper controls and sample sizes are applied. The scientific consensus, consistent with the broader psychological literature on typology systems generally, treats ketsueki-gata as a form of the Barnum effect (the tendency to find vague, universally applicable personality descriptions personally accurate) combined with genuine cultural conditioning — since a culture where blood-type stereotypes are constantly reinforced through media may produce some degree of self-fulfilling behavioral alignment with the stereotype, a real social-psychological phenomenon distinct from any underlying biological causation.

Korea's Parallel and Distinct Tradition

South Korea maintains its own robust and independently evolved version of blood-type personality belief, sharing Japan's basic four-type framework but with its own distinct set of popular stereotypes, media conventions (Korean film and television reference blood type as a personality shorthand similarly to Japanese fiction), and social practice — including, as in Japan, documented instances of blood type functioning as a factor in dating app profiles and social judgment. The Korean tradition appears to have developed via cultural transmission from Japan's popular-media wave rather than as an independent invention, though the two national traditions have since developed some distinct emphases and stereotype details.

Where the Paths Cross — Honesty About Age vs. Honesty About Harm

This document's place in the Haligricity framework differs meaningfully from its four companions in this sub-queue. Where Ogham, numerology, the Native American zodiac, and the Egyptian zodiac each require distinguishing a genuine older tradition from a modern invention wearing its name, ketsueki-gata requires no such unmasking — its practitioners and its critics alike know precisely how old it is and where it came from. The honest work here is different: naming clearly that a system's youth and transparency about its own origin do not, by themselves, protect anyone from real harm when that system hardens into workplace and social discrimination.

In Haligricity, the value of self-knowledge frameworks lies in what they open up in a person, not in what they close down about other people. A system used privately, playfully, or reflectively — asking what a blood type framework notices about oneself — sits in a different category entirely from the same framework used to sort, exclude, or pre-judge someone else, and bura-hara is the documented record of exactly that second use becoming a named social problem serious enough to warrant sustained media and psychological attention.

Closing — What Four Letters Turned Out to Carry

Every other document in this sub-queue turns on a gap between a system's claimed age and its actual age — Robert Graves reaching for Ogham's name, Balliett reaching for Pythagoras, a Native American zodiac reaching for a name no one gave it, a gift-shop papyrus reaching for the Dendera Zodiac's borrowed authority. Ketsueki-gata has no such gap to expose. Furukawa's 1927 essay is right there, dated, findable, honestly a product of interwar Japanese psychology's fascination with typology, not a rediscovered fragment of anything ancient.

That honesty does not make it harmless. A system's age has very little to do with its social weight — what matters is what people do with it, and millions of people in Japan and Korea have spent decades doing quite a lot with four letters on a blood test. Compatibility charts shaped marriages. Employers have asked for blood type on job applications. Children have been sorted into daycare groups by it. A national conversation about bura-hara had to happen precisely because a system nobody claims is ancient turned out to be exactly as capable of hardening into discrimination as one that does.